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Sophomore College Planning Night





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Preparing for Junior Year and the College Application Process

Tonight we will cover:

- ❑ Academic planning and the importance of junior year
- ❑ Testing strategy and timelines
- ❑ Beginning the college essay conversation
- ❑ Planning a meaningful summer
- ❑ How Bishop Moore supports students through the process



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The College Admissions Timeline

Sophomore

- ❑ Academic foundation
- ❑ Exploration of interests
- ❑ Begin thinking about testing strategy
- ❑ Test Prep Begins End of Sophomore year

Junior

- ❑ Test Prep begins Summer before Junior year
- ❑ Most important academic year
- ❑ Testing begins
- ❑ Essay writing process begins

Senior

- ❑ Applications submitted
- ❑ Final college decisions



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The Importance of Sophomore Year Final Grades

Sophomore year is about **building the academic foundation**, your grades help colleges see **academic growth and consistency**.

Admissions officers ask:

- ☐ Is the student building strong academic habits?
- ☐ Are grades improving over time?
- ☐ Is the student ready for more challenging coursework?

Final sophomore grades become part of the **academic transcript colleges review when applications open in senior year**.



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Why Junior Year is the Most Important Academic Year

Junior year is the **last full year of grades** colleges see when making admissions decisions.

When students apply in the fall of senior year, colleges review:

- ☐ Freshman grades
- ☐ Sophomore grades
- ☐ **Junior year final transcript**

Junior year is when students demonstrate readiness for college-level work.



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Preparing for a Strong Junior Year

Students should enter junior year with a plan.

- ☐ Thoughtful course selection
- ☐ Time management and organization
- ☐ Continued commitment to activities and leadership
- ☐ Using Maia to take personal assessments, explore careers, and research majors
- ☐ Attend college rep visits in the fall
- ☐ Build relationships with teachers

Recommendation Letters for applications are strongest when they are from a junior year teacher



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Testing Strategy and Timeline

Standardized testing is still an important component of the college process for many schools.

Summer before Junior Year

- Begin test preparation
- Take diagnostic SAT or ACT



Junior Year

February

- ☐ First official SAT or ACT

Spring (March–April)

- ☐ Continue test preparation

June or July

- ☐ Target final score window

The goal is to **secure a strong score before senior year begins.**



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The College Essay Conversation

College essays allow admissions officers to see **who students are beyond grades and activities.**

Strong Essays often reveal:

- ❑ Personal growth
- ❑ Intellectual curiosity
- ❑ Values or identity
- ❑ Moments that shaped a student's perspective

The goal is not to impress, but to reveal something authentic to admissions representatives.



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The College Essay Process

College essays allow admissions officers to see **who students are beyond grades and activities.**

Step 1

- ❑ Students meet with their **college counselor in English class**
- ❑ They discuss:
 - Potential essay topics
 - How to shape their story strategically

Step 2

- ❑ Students write their main essay as part of the English curriculum.

Step 3

- ❑ The essay is shared with the counseling office.
- ❑ Counselors provide strategic feedback.

Step 4

- ❑ Students work with the **Writing Center** to finalize edits.



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College Application Bootcamp

In the **spring of junior year**, students participate in a full-day program:
Junior College Application Bootcamp

This on-campus event helps students begin the application process in a structured way.

During Bootcamp students will:

- ☐ Begin editing the **Common Application**
- ☐ Review and set up their **STARS account**
- ☐ Revisit their **main essay progress**
- ☐ Discuss strategy for **supplemental essays**
- ☐ Plan a **strategic summer before senior year**



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Campus Visits

Never underestimate the power of a meaningful campus visit.

- ❑ Plan ahead /RSVP - multiple stops, same location.
- ❑ Professional presentation of self
- ❑ Learn about academics, activities, services, housing, surrounding community
 - Take notes to compare!
- ❑ Winter visits for northern schools

Experiencing the campus vibe and student activity can be central to finding fit.



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Planning a Meaningful Summer

The summer before junior year is an opportunity for students to **explore their interests more deeply.**

Strong summer experiences may include:

- ☐ Academic programs
- ☐ Research opportunities
- ☐ Internships
- ☐ Jobs
- ☐ Volunteer work
- ☐ Independent projects

The key is **depth and connectivity of involvement**, not simply collecting activities.



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Why Summer Experiences Matter

Meaningful summer experiences help students:

- ☐ Explore potential academic interests
- ☐ Strengthen their college resume
- ☐ Gain real-world experiences
- ☐ Develop stories they will later write about in their essays

* Imagine their ideal college experience and campus

These experiences help students clarify their:

- ☐ “Why this major?”
- ☐ “Why this field?”
- ☐ “Why this college?”



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The Goal of the Process

The college process is not about building the perfect resume.

It is about helping students discover:

- ☐ What they are curious about
- ☐ What they enjoy learning
- ☐ Where they want to make an impact

When students pursue interests authentically, the application becomes **a reflection of who they are becoming.**



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Looking Ahead

The next two years are a time for students to:

- ☐ Challenge themselves academically
- ☐ Explore their interests
- ☐ Grow as learners and leaders

Our counseling office will guide students through every step of the process.

We look forward to working closely with you and your families.



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maia



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Thank You!

